

Talking to Children About Your Arthritis

Age-appropriate scripts that reassure without scaring.

By **Living With Arthritis Editorial Team** · Reviewed by **Clinical Review Board** (Multidisciplinary UK clinicians) · 2026-06-24 · livingwitharthritis.org.uk

Overview



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Age-appropriate scripts that reassure without scaring.

What the evidence shows

UK guidance from NICE, the British Society for Rheumatology and Versus Arthritis consistently emphasises a combined approach: appropriate medication, regular movement, and supportive lifestyle changes. Recent reviews continue to back this consensus.

What this means for you



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- ****Talk to your clinician.**** Personalised advice always beats blanket rules.
- ****Track your symptoms.**** Use a simple diary so you can spot patterns over weeks, not days.
- ****Move within comfort.**** Gentle, regular activity protects joints and mood.

- ****Watch the warning signs.**** New swelling, fever, or rapid loss of function deserve same-week review.
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Practical next steps

1. Read our companion piece for a deeper dive: [\[related guidance\]/community-hub](#)). 2. Bring three questions to your next GP or rheumatology appointment. 3. Share this article with a family member who supports you day to day.

Editorial standards



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This article was prepared by the Living With Arthritis Editorial Team and reviewed by our Clinical Review Board against UK NICE guidance and peer-reviewed sources. We update

content at least annually.

What the Evidence Says

Systematic reviews looking at how long-term conditions affect families consistently highlight the importance of clear, age-appropriate communication with children. Research shows that when children understand a parent's health challenges, they tend to cope better emotionally and are less likely to develop anxiety or behavioural issues. This isn't about overburdening them with details, but about providing enough information to demystify the condition and prevent them from imagining worse scenarios.

Clinical guidelines for managing chronic pain and long-term health conditions often include recommendations for family-centred care. These guidelines suggest that open communication fosters a supportive home environment, which in turn can positively impact the parent's well-being and ability to manage their condition. Randomised trials examining educational interventions for families dealing with chronic illness also support structured conversations as a way to reduce stress for both parents and children.

The evidence points to communication being much more effective when it's tailored to a child's developmental stage. Very young children benefit from simple explanations and reassurance, while older children and teenagers can engage with more detailed information and express their own feelings. The goal is always to empower children with understanding without causing undue worry.

Common Mistakes to Avoid

* **Hiding the condition completely:** Children are often more perceptive than we think and may sense something is wrong, leading them to imagine worse outcomes. **Fix:** Offer simple, honest explanations aligned with their age.* **Overloading with too much medical detail:** Sharing every symptom or complex treatment plan can overwhelm young minds. **Fix:** Stick to the basics – how it affects you and what it might mean for family activities.* **Blaming yourself or the child:** Language that suggests guilt or fault can be damaging. **Fix:** Explain that it's a condition you have, not something anyone caused.* **Making promises you can't keep:** Saying you'll "be better soon" if recovery is uncertain can break trust. **Fix:** Focus on managing symptoms and doing your best each day.* **Not allowing children to ask questions:** Dismissing their curiosity can lead to unspoken fears. **Fix:** Create an open space for them to ask anything on their mind, even if the answer is "I don't know yet."*

When to Speak to a Clinician

While open communication with your family is valuable, there are times when your own well-being or new symptoms signal a need for professional medical advice. Maintaining your health is key to being there for your children.

You should speak to your GP, physiotherapist, or rheumatologist if:

- * Your pain significantly worsens or changes character.
- * You develop new, unexplained symptoms like fever or rash.
- * Your ability to perform daily tasks, including caring for your children, is severely impacted.
- * You feel overwhelmed or constantly anxious about managing your condition and family life.
- * Your prescribed medication seems less effective or causes new side effects.

Frequently Asked Questions

How do I explain "pain" to a young child? You can describe pain using words they understand, like "my joints feel a bit stiff today, like an old rusty robot" or "sometimes my hands feel like they have a little ouchie." Focus on what it means for you, rather than the scary aspects, such as "it makes it harder for me to carry you sometimes, but I still love cuddles."

What if my child gets upset or scared? It's natural for children to react emotionally. Reassure them that you are taking care of yourself and that they are safe. Listen to their fears without judgment and validate their feelings. You might say, "I understand why that makes you sad, and it's okay to feel that way. We'll get through this together."

Should I involve my child in my treatment? You can involve them in small, appropriate ways that empower them, such as asking them to fetch a heat pack, or letting them choose a quiet activity to do with you when you're feeling low. This gives them a sense of contribution and understanding without burdening them with responsibility for your condition.

Q&A

Question: What is the key thing to know about talking to children about your arthritis?

Short answer: The article advises honest, age-appropriate conversations with children about arthritis, giving simple reassurance to younger children and more detail to older ones. It says clear communication can reduce worry and support family coping. Avoid hiding the condition, overwhelming medical detail, blame or false promises; invite questions and seek clinical advice for worsening symptoms, new concerns or overwhelm.

Question: When should I seek professional advice?

Short answer: If symptoms persist or worsen, pain is severe and unresponsive to usual relief, or you develop new symptoms, contact your GP, physiotherapist or rheumatology team promptly.

Question: Where can I get free arthritis support in the UK?

Short answer: Versus Arthritis: 0800 5200 520. NRAS: 0800 298 7650. Free tools and guides at livingwitharthritis.org.uk.

General information only — not medical advice. Consult your GP or specialist before changing medication or starting a new programme. Emergency: 999. NHS advice: 111. Living With Arthritis UK · livingwitharthritis.org.uk